DIY CONCRETE GARDEN SCULPTURES

Step-by-Step DIY Guide

Cast Stunning Sculptures, Figurines & Decorative Urns for Your Garden

Hand-cast concrete sculptures and decorative urns displayed in a lush summer garden

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About This Project

Concrete is one of the most versatile sculpting materials available — it's cheap, incredibly strong, and captures detail beautifully. In this guide you'll learn how to cast your own garden sculptures: figurines, abstract art pieces, decorative urns, and flower-shaped planters — all using simple molds and basic concrete mix. These are the kind of pieces that make visitors stop and ask 'where did you get that?' The answer: you made it yourself.

Difficulty	Beginner to Intermediate
Active time	1–3 hours per sculpture
Curing time	24–48 hours
Cost per piece	$5–25 USD depending on size and mold
Retail equivalent	$50–300 USD per piece in garden centres
Best for	Garden art, gifts, outdoor decor, selling at markets
Weather resistance	Excellent — concrete lasts outdoors for decades

Materials & Tools

#	Item	Notes
1	Concrete mix (fine-grain)	Use craft concrete or fine-grain mix for detail work. Coarse concrete is for slabs — fi
2	Sculpture molds	Silicone figurine molds, flower-shaped molds, urn/vase molds. Available online (sear
3	Pedestal mold	A round or tapered shape for the base. An inverted plastic cup, PVC pipe offcut, or p
4	Water	Clean tap water. Mix ratio: 2.5 parts concrete to 1 part water.
5	Mixing bucket + stir stick	A 5-litre bucket is enough for most sculpture pours.
6	Trowel or palette knife	For pressing concrete into detailed mold areas and smoothing.
7	Wooden skewer / toothpick	For poking concrete into fine detail areas of the mold without trapping air.
8	Nitrile gloves	Essential — wet concrete is alkaline and damages skin.
9	Cooking spray / mold release	Coat all mold surfaces before pouring — critical for clean demolding.
10	Sandpaper (120–220 grit)	For smoothing rough edges and seams after demolding.
11	Concrete bonding adhesive	To attach a sculpture to its pedestal permanently.
12	Masonry sealer	Protects the finished sculpture from weathering and frost damage.
13	Concrete pigment (optional)	Add to the mix for terracotta, charcoal, or aged stone colours.
14	Wire brush	For distressing/aging the surface after curing — creates an authentic antique stone lo
15	Acrylic paint + dry brush	Optional — dry-brush highlights in cream or gold for a weathered, aged patina effect.

■ ***Mold tip:*** *The best sculpture molds are food-grade silicone baking molds — they release perfectly and capture incredible detail. Check kitchen stores and online — gnomes, animals, angels, and abstract shapes are all available.*

Step-by-Step Instructions

Step 1 — Choose Your Molds & Plan the Sculpture

Before mixing any concrete, decide on your sculpture design. In the video, the maker casts figurines, abstract decorative pieces, and large flower-shaped planters — all from different molds. Each mold type requires slightly different techniques, covered in the steps below.

- Silicone molds work best for detailed figurines — they flex open for clean release.
- Plastic molds (buckets, containers, PVC pipe) are ideal for pedestals and simple shapes.
- For abstract free-form sculptures, build up concrete by hand over a wire armature.
- Always test-fit your mold pieces together before pouring — gaps cause concrete to leak.
- Spray ALL mold surfaces with cooking spray or wipe with petroleum jelly before every pour.

> ■ ***Planning tip:*** *Sketch your final garden display before making any pieces — decide which sculptures will have pedestals, which will sit directly on the ground, and how they'll be grouped together for visual impact.*

Step 2 — Mix the Concrete

Mixing fine-grain concrete to a smooth, workable consistency — the foundation of every piece

Mix fine-grain concrete with water to a consistency like thick yoghurt — smooth, pourable, but not watery. The ratio is **2.5 parts dry mix to 1 part water**. Mix thoroughly for 3 minutes until completely lump-free.

- Add water slowly — a slightly stiffer mix holds mold detail better.

- For sculptures with fine detail: mix slightly stiffer (less water) so it holds crisp edges.
- For large pours (urns, planters): slightly wetter mix flows into corners more easily.
- Tap the mixing bucket on the table several times after mixing to release trapped air.
- Add concrete pigment now if using colour — mix until fully uniform before pouring.

■ ***Tip:*** *Mix only what you can use in 20–30 minutes. Concrete begins stiffening quickly — don't try to revive thickened mix with extra water.*

Step 3 — Pour into the Mold

Pouring concrete into a flower-shaped mold — filling every petal cavity evenly

Pour concrete slowly and steadily into the mold, working from the centre outward. For figurine molds with fine details, use a small spoon or palette knife to press concrete into the detailed areas first, then fill the rest by pouring.

- Pour in a thin stream — not a splash — to reduce air bubbles.
- Use a wooden skewer to poke concrete into fine detail areas (fingers, faces, petals).
- Tap the mold firmly on the table for 30–60 seconds after pouring — this is the most important step for bubble-free results.
- Fill to the top of the mold, then scrape level with a flat edge.
- For two-part molds: pour one half, let firm for 1 hour, then pour the second half.

■ ***For flower molds:*** *Pour concrete into each petal separately first, then fill the centre. This ensures every petal fills completely without voids.*

Step 4 — Cure for 24–48 Hours

Leave filled molds completely undisturbed on a flat surface for 24–48 hours. Cover loosely with plastic to prevent dust and slow the cure. In hot weather, mist lightly every few hours to prevent cracking.

- 24 hours: minimum for demolding small pieces.
- 48 hours: recommended for large sculptures or any piece that will be handled.
- 28 days: full concrete strength — avoid heavy impacts until then.

- Keep in shade during curing — direct sun dries the surface too fast and causes cracking.

> ■ ***Tip:*** *Cast multiple pieces in one session — mix a large batch and fill as many molds as you have. The setup and cleanup time is the same whether you make one or ten.*

Step 5 — Demold & Refine

Demolding a raw concrete sculpture — the rough textured surface reveals the form

After curing, flex silicone molds from all sides and peel back slowly to release. For plastic molds, cut away the mold if needed. The raw concrete will be rough — this is normal and expected.

- Peel silicone slowly and evenly — rushing causes edges to chip.
- Sand seam lines (where mold halves met) with 120-grit sandpaper.
- Use a wire brush to refine the surface texture — more brushing creates a more aged, weathered look.
- Fill any voids or pinholes with a paste of cement + water, applied with a finger or brush.
- Rinse with water to clean off concrete dust before finishing.

> ■ ***Texture tip:*** *The rough, slightly imperfect surface of hand-cast concrete is part of the beauty — it gives sculptures an authentic, aged stone quality that perfectly-smooth factory pieces lack.*

Step 6 — Cast the Pedestals

Pedestals elevate sculptures off the ground, create visual height variation in the garden, and protect sculptures from soil moisture. Cast your pedestal in a tapered or round mold — an inverted plastic bucket, a PVC pipe section, or a purpose-made pedestal mold.

- Pedestal height: 30–60 cm works for most garden sculptures.
- Cast with a hollow centre (insert a smaller tube/container in the middle) to reduce weight.
- Reinforce with a piece of rebar or wooden dowel running through the centre while wet.

- After curing, attach the sculpture to the pedestal with masonry adhesive (Liquid Nails or similar).
- Let adhesive cure 24 hours before standing the piece upright.

> ■ ***Tip:*** *A slightly wider base than top looks more stable and elegant. Taper your pedestal mold by using two different-diameter containers for inner and outer forms.*

Step 7 — Age & Finish the Sculptures

Finished concrete sculptures placed in the garden — figurine on pedestal with abstract art piece

Raw concrete looks beautiful on its own, but a few finishing techniques transform it into something that looks genuinely aged and artisan-made.

Natural weathering	Simply place outdoors and let rain, moss, and time do the work. Within 6–12 months concrete develops a natural patina that looks stunning.
Wire brush aging	Brush the surface firmly in all directions with a stiff wire brush after curing. This opens the texture and creates an aged, rough stone appearance immediately.
Dry brush highlights	Dip a stiff brush in cream or white acrylic paint, wipe most of it off on a paper towel, then lightly drag across the raised surfaces. The paint catches the high points only, creating a beautiful carved stone effect.
Moss growing	Blend live moss with buttermilk and paint onto the sculpture. Keep moist — moss begins growing within 2–4 weeks, creating a beautifully aged, forest-floor appearance.

Iron oxide patina	Mix iron oxide powder with water and brush on, then immediately wipe off. The oxide settles in the low points, creating a deep, rich aged effect.

Step 8 — Display in Your Garden

A hand-cast concrete figurine on its pedestal — a statement piece in any garden

Multiple sculptures and decorative urns grouped together for a gallery-style garden display

Placement is everything with garden sculpture. A single piece can anchor a whole garden corner; a group of three creates a gallery-style focal point that draws the eye and invites exploration.

- Place sculptures at the END of sight lines — so you see them as you look down a path or across the garden.
- Group in odd numbers (3 or 5) — odd groupings look more natural and dynamic than pairs.
- Vary the heights — combine a tall pedestal piece with a low ground-level piece and a medium urn.
- Position near plants that will grow around them — moss, ferns, and hostas frame concrete beautifully.
- Apply a concrete sealer before placing outdoors — 2 coats, let dry 24 hours between each.

The Finished Garden

A complete hand-cast concrete garden — sculptures, figurines, and decorative urns in a lush summer setting

Pro Tips & Sculpture Ideas

★ Use hypertufa for lightweight sculptures	Mix 1 part Portland cement + 1.5 parts peat moss + 1.5 parts perlite. This hypertufa mix is 40% lighter than standard concrete, has a beautiful rough texture, and is perfect for large garden pieces.
★ Cast faces and hands with latex molds	Press your hand or face into clay to make an impression, then pour liquid latex into the impression to create a mold. Once set, pour concrete into the latex mold for remarkably detailed results.
★ Build abstract sculptures over wire armature	Bend and twist galvanized wire into an abstract form, then apply concrete over it like papier-mâché — layer by layer. Every piece will be completely unique and genuinely artistic.
★ Make matching urn planters	The goblet/urn shapes shown in the video are perfect planters. Cast them in pairs for a formal, symmetrical garden entrance — fill with trailing flowers like petunias for a stunning effect.
★ Try different concrete colours per piece	White cement makes alabaster-like sculptures. Terracotta pigment gives a classic Italian garden look. Charcoal creates dramatic modern pieces. Varying the colour across a collection makes the display more interesting.
★ Sell at craft markets	Hand-cast concrete garden sculptures typically sell for $40–150 each at markets, depending on size and detail. A set of three small figurines retails for $60–120. Cost to make: $3–15 each. Margin is excellent.
★ Protect with anti-freeze sealer in cold climates	Standard masonry sealer is not enough in freeze-thaw climates. Use a penetrating silane-siloxane sealer which prevents water entering the concrete — water expansion during freezing is what cracks outdoor sculptures.
★ Cast in winter for spring reveal	Concrete cures faster at 15–20°C than in summer heat. Cast your sculptures indoors in winter, cure slowly, finish and seal — then reveal them in spring when the garden comes back to life.

Troubleshooting

✗ Problem: Sculpture has large voids / hollow spots

✓ **Solution:** Air was trapped during pouring. Next time: pour slower, use a skewer to poke concrete into all areas, and tap the mold for longer (60+ seconds). Fill existing voids with fresh cement slurry and sand smooth once dry.

✗ Problem: Fine details didn't transfer

✓ **Solution:** Concrete mix was too stiff, or the mold wasn't coated with release agent. Use a slightly wetter mix for detail work, and always apply mold release before pouring. A soft brush can work wet concrete into fine detail areas before the main pour.

✗ Problem: Sculpture cracked during or after curing

✓ **Solution:** Dried too fast, or was moved too early. Keep in shade and mist regularly for the first 24 hours. Hairline cracks can be filled with cement slurry. Larger cracks indicate demolding too early.

✗ Problem: Pedestal feels unstable

✓ **Solution:** The base is too narrow or the sculpture too heavy on top. Cast a wider base next time, or embed a steel rod through the centre during casting to connect pedestal to sculpture permanently.

✗ Problem: Mold release failed — stuck in mold

✓ **Solution:** Not enough release agent, or the mold has micro-cracks. Flex the mold vigorously in all directions. For plastic molds, cut away the mold. Re-coat all molds with release agent before every single pour.

✗ Problem: Finished surface looks too smooth / unnatural

✓ **Solution:** Standard molds produce a smooth finish. Use a wire brush, coarse sandpaper, or a Dremel with a grinding bit to add texture. The rough, hand-worked surface is what makes concrete sculptures look authentic.

Thank you for your purchase!

A garden filled with things you made yourself is a garden with a soul. Every piece you cast tells the story of an afternoon well spent.

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